Software Testing With Users Compliance Form – UG & PGT Projects*

School of Engineering and Informatics, University of Sussex

This form should be used in conjunction with the document entitled "Ethical Review Guidance for Student Projects".

Prior to conducting your project, you and your supervisor must discuss the ethical implications of your project. If your proposed project complies with **all** of the points in this form, then may use this form.

If you use this form, you must also prepare either (a) an information sheet and a consent for your participant to sign, or (b) prepare an Introduction and Debriding Script to read to your participant before the test (see appendix below). These must be approved by you supervisor.

Include the signed copy of this form with your final project report/dissertation.

If your proposed project does not comply with all the points, you should refer back to the "Research Ethics Guidance for UG and PGT Projects" document for further guidance.

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1. Participants were not exposed to any risks greater than those encountered in their normal working life.

   You have a responsibility to protect participants from physical, mental and emotional harm during the testing. The risk of harm must be no greater than in ordinary life. Areas of potential risk that require ethical approval include, but are not limited to, investigations that require participant mobility (e.g. walking, running, use of public transport), unusual or repetitive activity or movement, physical hazards or discomfort, emotional distress, use of sensory deprivation (e.g. ear plugs or blindfolds), sensitive topics (e.g. sexual activity, drug use, political behaviour, ethnicity) or those which might induce discomfort, stress or anxiety (e.g. violent video games), bright or flashing lights, loud or disorienting noises, smell, taste, vibration, or force feedback.

2. The study materials are paper-based or comprises software running on standard hardware.

   Participants should not be exposed to any risks associated with the use of non-standard equipment: anything other than pen-and-paper, standard PCs, mobile phones, and tablet computers is considered non-standard.

3. All participants must explicitly state that they agreed to take part, and that their data can be used in the project.

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*This form was originally developed by Professor Steven Brewster at the University of Glasgow, and modified by Dr Judith Good for use at the University of Sussex with his permission.

Participants cannot take part in the test without their knowledge or consent (i.e. no covert observation). Covert observation, deception or withholding information are deemed to be high risk and require ethical approval through the relevant F-REC.

If the results of the evaluation are likely to be used beyond the term of the project (for example, the software is to be deployed, the data is to be published or there are future secondary uses of the data), then it will be necessary to obtain signed consent from each participant. Otherwise, verbal consent is sufficient, and should be explicitly requested in the introductory script (see Appendix 1).

4. No incentives will be offered to the participants.
   The payment of participants must not be used to induce them to risk harm beyond that which they risk without payment in their normal lifestyle. People volunteering to participate may be compensated financially e.g. for reasonable travel expenses. Payments made to individuals must not be so large as to induce individuals to risk harm beyond that which they would usually undertake.

5. No information about the evaluation or materials is intentionally withheld from the participants.
   Withholding information from participants or misleading them is unacceptable without justifiable reasons for doing so. Any projects requiring deception (for example, only telling participants of the true purpose of the study afterwards so as not to influence their behaviour) are deemed high risk and require approval from the relevant F-REC.

6. No participant is under the age of 18.
   Any studies involving children or young people are deemed to be high risk and require ethical approval through the relevant F-REC.

7. No participant has a disability or impairment that may have limited their understanding or communication or capacity to consent.
   Projects involving participants with disabilities are deemed to be high risk and require ethical approval from the relevant F-REC.

8. Neither I nor my supervisor are in a position of authority or influence over any of the participants.
   A position of authority or influence over any participant must not be allowed to pressurise participants to take part in, or remain in, any study.

9. All participants will be informed that they can withdraw at any time.
   All participants have the right to withdraw at any time during the investigation. They should be told this in the introductory script (see Appendix 1).

10. All participants will be informed of my contact details, and the contact details of my supervisor.
    All participants must be able to contact the investigator and/or the supervisor after the investigation. They should be given contact details for both student and supervisor as part of the debriefing.

11. The evaluation will be described in detail with all of the participants at the beginning of the session, and participants will be fully debriefed at the end of the session. All participants will be given the opportunity to ask questions at both the beginning and end of the session.

    Participants must be provided with sufficient information prior to starting the session, and in the debriefing, to enable them to understand the nature of the investigation.

12. All the data collected from the participants will be stored securely, and in an anonymous form.

    All participant data (hard-copy and soft-copy) should be stored securely (i.e. locked filing cabinets for hard copy, password protected computer for electronic data), and in an anonymised form.

Project title: AI-Powered Dynamic Narrative System for RPGs

Student's Name: Duncan Law

Student's Registration Number: 281967

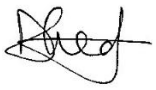
Student's Signature:

Date: 09/11/2025

Supervisor's Name: ____Dr Daniel Creed_____

I have read and authorised either (a) the participant information sheet and consent form or (b) the Introduction and Debrief scripts. Supervisor's Initials: ____DC_____

Supervisor's Signature: _____



Date:
_____09/11/2025_____

Software Testing With Users Compliance Form
Appendix 1: Introduction and Debriefing Scripts

If you intend to obtain verbal consent from your participants, you need to create an introduction script, to read out at the start of the study, and a debriefing script, to read out at the end of the study. You should get your supervisor's approval for your introduction and debriefing scripts before commencing your study. **NB: When submitting the signed Software Testing With Users Compliance form include your Introduction and Debriefing script.**

Introduction Script

The introduction script must:

- state the general aim of the study
- explain why you need the involvement of other people
- describe what will happen in the study
- describe what data will be collected
- reassure the participant that any data collected will be stored securely, and in an anonymous format
- explain what interaction the participant may have with you during the study
- reassure the participant that this is not a test of ability
- state that the participant may withdraw at any time
- seek explicit consent
- allow the participant to ask questions

An example introductory script (italics indicate required information, some of which will be specific to your project):

Web Interface Investigation
Final Year Project, 2020-21
Jane Student

The aim of this study is to investigate the [*state the general aim of the experiment – e.g., suitability of a new website*]. We cannot tell how good this [. . . .] is unless we ask those people who are likely to be using it, which is why we need to run studies like these [*explain why you need the involvement of other people*]. I will give you some time to [*describe the tasks in involved in general terms*], before asking you to answer some questions [*describe kinds of questions*].

I will be observing you while you perform the tasks [*describe what data will be collected*]. If you have any questions, please ask me, and please let me know when you are finished [*explain what interaction the participant may have with you during the study*].

I will ask you some questions at the end of the study [*describe what will happen in the study*]. Please remember that it is the system, not you, that is being evaluated [*reassure the participant that this is not a test of ability*].

You are welcome to withdraw from the study at any time [*state that the participant may withdraw at any time*]. Please be assured that any data collected will be stored securely and in an anonymous form [*describe how the data will be anonymised and stored*].

Do you agree to take part in this evaluation? [*seek explicit consent*]. Do you have any questions before we start? [*allow the participant to ask questions*].

Debriefing Script

The debriefing script that is used at the end of the study must:

- restate the main aim of the experiment
- if applicable, explain any other, related aims of the experiment, and any particular data collected
- allow the participant to make comments or ask questions
- give contact details for the student and supervisor
- thank the participant

An example debriefing script (italics indicate required information, some of which will be specific to your project):

Web Interface Investigation
Final Year Project, 2020-21
Jane Student

The main aim of the experiment was to investigate the suitability of this website [*restate the main aim of the experiment*]. In particular, I was looking to see whether you made use of the site map, and whether any of the links on the website seemed to be confusing. I wanted to know how easy the pages were to navigate [*if applicable, explain any other, related aims of the experiment, and any particular data collected*].

Do you have any comments or questions about the experiment? [*allow the participant to make comments or ask questions*]. Here are my contact details, and those of my supervisor, and please let us know if you have any further questions about this study [*give contact details of student and supervisor to participant*]. Thank you for your help [*thank the participant*].